subcontinent – the Indus, the Sutlej and the Brahmaputra – were all located in Tibet.

In a post-colonial world, it should have been apparent that the imperial fiction of ‘suzerainty’ versus sovereignty could not be upheld, especially in relation to a revolutionary Marxist regime in Beijing. China would see independent India’s insistence on inheriting the special status and privileges in Tibet that it had had under British rule, such as the trade marts in Yatung and Gyantse and the stationing of a detachment of Indian troops at these locations, as India’s nefarious designs on Tibet. When the 1959 anti-China revolt broke out in Lhasa and the Dalai Lama was given sanctuary in India, this convinced the Chinese leadership that India was engaged in subverting Chinese sovereignty over Tibet. The border skirmishes which had already been taking place since 1959 took on the character of a strategic threat, and this is what triggered the border war in 1962. Chinese archives make that very clear.

And yet Nehru adopted what proved to be an unusually myopic view concerning China’s occupation of Tibet. From the Nehru Papers accessed recently by a few scholars, Nehru had this to say about China and Tibet:

> Whatever may be the ultimate fate of Tibet in relation to China, I think there is practically no chance of any military danger arising from any possible change in Tibet. Geographically this is very difficult and practically it would be a foolish adventure. If India is to be influenced or an attempt made to bring pressure on her, Tibet is not the route for it. [6]

The ‘foolish adventure’ became a reality within the space of just a few years, with China’s border war with India in 1962.

India’s conflict with China over Tibet seemed inevitable, and yet when it erupted India was caught completely unprepared. The India–China border remains unresolved till today, and Tibet remains at the heart of this dispute. China is unlikely to settle the border unless it believes that its ‘core interest’ of Tibet is fully secured. And this is linked with the status of the Dalai Lama and the Tibetan community in India.

An additional controversy impacting India–China relations relates to the Karmapa, the head of one of the four major sects of Tibetan Buddhism, the Black Hat or the Karma Kagyu sect. [7] The Karma Kagyu sect has its seat at